At the border, Erich Honecker showed his most monstrous side. By 1967, the signs of an authoritarian state were there for everyone to see. That year, guards were told that border violators were to be ‘arrested or annihilated’.11 The regulations on ‘illegal border crossings’, was clearly laid out in paragraph 21312 of the criminal code, which stated that in severe cases, perpetrators would be sentenced to between one and five years, and preparations and attempts were also punishable:

Whoever illegally trespasses or stays within the territory of the German Democratic Republic; does not adhere to the legal provisions or imposed constraints regarding entry and exit, travel methods, or length of stay; uses false information to obtain permission for themselves or others to leave or enter the territory of the German Democratic Republic; or leaves the territory of the German Democratic Republic without the State’s permission or does not return will be punished with a prison sentence of up to two years, or probation, fines, or public censure.

In paragraph 105, the issue of ‘subversive human trafficking’, decreed that ‘whoever undertook to entice citizens of the German Democratic Republic to territories or countries outside of their homeland; to transport, transfer, or hinder their return, will be punished with a prison sentence of no less than two years’. By 1970, a reminder in the ‘Handbook for Border Guards’ included the horrifying line: ‘The preliminary arrest must be made by any means (for example using a well-aimed bullet)’, thus implying the death of individuals trying to flee was accepted as a possible consequence of the regulations.

From time to time, the Wall featured in the international press, as did news from wider society, where there were some notable successes for the SED regime. During 1967, GDR citizens celebrated the introduction of the five-